

RAVI S SAHANI



Caught in a Web

CHANDIGARH The long arm of the law has finally caught up with Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh, the spiritual head of the Sirsa-based sect, Dera Sacha Sauda. On July 26, a special CBI court ordered framing of rape charges against the god-man by August 23, putting him firmly in the dock. He is charged with raping a sadhvi (female disciple) at the sect's headquarters five years ago.

This has not only dealt a serious blow to Baba's

religious credentials but also signals the tightening of corners for him. The court is yet to decide on the other charges of the CBI against him for the murder of Sirsa journalist Ram Chander Chattarpati and his former driver-follower Ranjit Singh.

The damning court ruling comes soon after recent violent flare-ups between the sect followers and Sikh groups. The sect-Sikh tension, simmering for over a year since Baba offended

TOUGH TIMES: Baba Ram Rahim is charged with rape

the Sikh community by allegedly imitating Guru Gobind Singh, erupted at Dabwali near Sirsa in Haryana last week. It left a Sikh protester dead. This was the second such incident in the last two months as a Sikh was shot dead by the Baba's body-guard in Mumbai, triggering massive Sikh protests.

Two days after the court order, the Baba made a desperate attempt to buy peace with the enraged Sikh bodies. "Our doors are always open for a dialogue without any prejudice or preconditions," he said, breaking his long-kept silence at his heavily-guarded residence.

The radical Sikh bodies turned down his truce offer and ominously struck a 'fight-to-finish' threat against Baba, demanding his arrest and a ban on his religious congregations. The Baba will require more than divine intervention to ward off his legal wrangles and his virulent opponents. **by Ramesh Vinayak**

SIGNPOSTS

NAMED: Judge Navanethem Pillay, 67, as the new UN high commissioner for human rights. She is a judge of the International Criminal Court in the Hague since 2003.



WON: By golfer Jeev Milkha Singh, the Nagashima Shigeo Invitational

Sega Sammy Cup in Hokkaido, Japan. This is his second title of the season.

AWARDED: To Dr Harsh K. Gupta and Professor Sulochana Gadgil, the National Award for Ocean Science and Technology and the National Award for Atmospheric Sciences respectively. The awards were given by the Ministry of Earth Sciences.

APPOINTED: Sameera Salim Kazi as chief of Goa's first Protection of Child Rights Commission. It will provide speedy trial of offences against children and violation of child rights.

VIS-A-VIS YASHWANT SINHA BJP leader versus MANMOHAN SINGH prime minister

India is sitting on a powder keg. Scrapping of POTA has made the country a soft target. POTA should be revived.



SAURABH SINGH

The attacks on Parliament and Akshardham temple occurred when POTA was in force. There is no dearth of laws to deal with terrorism.

EPILOGUE: Laws alone cannot stop terrorism unless they are backed by determination.